

On
Fate and Providence

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Introduction.

It is impossible, by an ordinary consideration of historical events, to recognize the difference between fate and providence.

When Jerusalem was destroyed, the Jew said: "it is Jehovah, who avenges the transgression of his law"; the Nazarene said: "it is the blood of the Crucified One that comes upon the head of the people"; but the Roman said: "it is fate."

As the Jew, the Nazarene, and the Roman then judged, each according to his mood and his standpoint, so to this very day every party and every human being judges, according to mood and standpoint, of every historical event. It does not, then, depend on the event, but on the mood and the standpoint.

It is impossible, by an ordinary consideration of the particular remarkable occurrences in the lives of particular human beings, to make a distinction between fate and providence.

[4] Two human beings can outwardly experience the same incidents, come into the same dangers, be saved in the same unexpected and wonderful way: the one sees in all this a play of fate, the other sees a providence. It does not, then, depend at all on what it is that is experienced, but on *how* it is experienced; it does not depend on the occurrence, but on the way of thinking.

It is impossible for a human being to have his faith in providence directly confirmed by the events that meet him; for he must, after all, interpret all events according to his faith. If prosperity comes: it is providence; if adversity comes: it is also providence; if everything in existence is comprehensible and happy, and the future bright: it is providence; if everything in existence is confused and troublesome, and the future dark: it is also providence.

He who does not thus in everything subordinate his own human judgment to his faith in providence does not believe in providence at all.

But if events, in history as well as in the lives of particular human beings, admit of being interpreted in such widely different ways, then, as regards fate and providence, we can learn nothing, absolutely nothing, from the course of events.

[5]

A.

On Fate.

I.

What Is Fate?

The cold, inflexible, and yet so capricious, arbitrary power which we call fate is essentially grounded in the interconnection of natural things, in the law-governed order of existence, that is, in the world-reason itself.

The law of reason and the necessity conditioned by it are, however, in and for themselves by no means yet to be called fate. Insofar as the things that exist immediately subordinate themselves to the universally valid laws, necessity, the outer as well as the inner, is to be regarded as the ground of reciprocal action, of wholeness, and of harmony. The course of the stars, the change of the seasons, the growth of [6] plants, all such things are grounded in the interconnection of nature, and insofar in necessity; but here there is no fate.

Only in the animal world, where individual life expresses itself with self-awareness and selfish purpose, does fate begin to dawn. What an animal cannot suffer; how various, in this respect, is the fate of animals: the caged bird and the free bird each have their own fate; and then the fate of domestic animals, — if horses and asses could speak!

But horses and asses cannot speak; this imperfection mitigates their fate. The animal's dependence on instinct, its lostness in the moment, the dimness of its consciousness, which veils the possibilities of the future and hides the past in oblivion, prevents it from setting itself up as a free end in itself, bends it gently under the yoke of natural necessity, and is like a covering that deadens the blows of fate.

Only where there is a self-purpose, a plan of the will, a personal goal, can there be talk of a power that crows the purpose, thwarts the plan, and disrupts the goal. Among all earthly creatures, therefore, man is the only one to whom nature has [7] granted the great, ambiguous privilege that, in the proper sense, so long as he stands on the ground of worldliness, he is to stand under fate. Rich endowments, mighty will, bold spirit, all the natural gifts of personality cannot save him from the dark, enigmatic power; for the greater the personality, the mightier fate. Fate is the enemy of all that is personal; therefore the gods must feel its power, therefore Jupiter with his thunderbolt must bow before *Fatum*.

II.

The Dominion of Fate.

If it is a distinguishing mark of fate that it everywhere confronts personality with hostility, then it follows that its dominion must be as extensive as personal striving.

In the acquisition of temporal goods, in the sphere of ideas, indeed even in the moral, we must distinguish between that which depends on us and that which does not depend on us. If now that which does not depend on us took account of our [8] personal need, and came to the aid of our rational will, then it would not be fate, but a higher wisdom governing all. Viewed in worldly terms, the reverse is just the case. The universal superior power on which our striving depends is so far from heeding the personal in us that it rather behaves indifferently, indeed even mockingly toward it: this is precisely the fatal thing.

If we consider the difference between the healthy and the sick, the rich and the poor, the high and the low in the world, it is seen at first glance that the distribution of temporal goods by no means takes place according to need and merit, but that the distributing world-power has followed arbitrariness, has let fortune and misfortune, good luck and bad luck rule the division, and, in the guise of good luck as well as bad luck, has made a fool of human personality.

If we turn from the outer to the inner, a similar arbitrariness repeats itself. It is a human privilege to be able to rise above the particular, the petty, to set ourselves universally valid goals, that is to say: to live for ideas. But this privilege is not equal [9] for all; here we meet the fateful difference between the gifted and the ungifted, the spirited and the spiritless. The expression, to live for an idea, is moreover ambiguous so long as it is left undetermined to which sphere the idea belongs. There are personal and impersonal ideas.

The ideas of art, science, and the state are impersonal; the idea of morality is personal.

To live for an impersonal idea is to give oneself up to the impersonal. Every spiritual devotion to the spiritual heightens the self-feeling; therefore geniuses and the inspired have such a powerful intense life in themselves. But the impersonal finally gains the superior power. The bond of inwardness that binds the distinguished to the idea and makes them its powerful instruments is at the same time the chain in which fate catches personality and binds it to its wheel: the work is completed, the master perishes; the idea triumphs, its instrument lies shattered (a Columbus,

a Kepler, a Mozart, a Fulton could, each in his own language, give an explanation). Hard is fate when it arbitrarily distributes the finite goods, plays with the fortunate and torments the unfortunate; but cruel is it when, as impersonal idea, it steals into the inner being of man and sucks the blood of personality. [10]

In order to withstand fate, man ought therefore to submit himself to the moral world-order and practice virtue, for the idea of virtue is personal. This counsel is old and good, but, understood in worldly terms, insufficient; as far as the laws of nature extend, so far extends also fate's realm.

As we distinguish, with regard to the impersonal ideas, between the gifted and the ungifted, so we must, with regard to the moral idea, make a distinction between noble and ignoble natures. The moral natural dispositions seem, namely, to be as arbitrarily distributed as the talents and the temporal goods. There are individuals who cannot but be pious, virtuous, lovable, because it lies in their nature; and there are individuals who by nature are as good as predestined to crime. Certainly man has what is called a free will; but what can the will do against passion? what becomes in reality of the moral will, where the natural ground is lacking? Half-heartedness, hypocrisy, quackery, mediocrity! The will grips powerfully only when it is itself [11] powerfully gripped, but it is gripped powerfully only by that which dawns on the inner sense, and satisfies personally. If now the moral idea has its validity solely in personal self-satisfaction, then he who satisfies himself in what is bad, when he really satisfies himself, is just as justified as he who satisfies himself in what is good; the difference is set by fate and is erased again by fate; for death makes us all equal: death is the last fate.

III.

The Struggle against Fate.

The worldly universal spirit is an impersonal spirit that would devour the human self; worldly personality is at bottom an egoistic personality, which in defiance of the universal would assert the human self. Between the impersonal universal and the egoistic personal the relation is strained. The superior power of the impersonal in the relation is fate; therefore personality struggles against it, and maintains itself, as far as it is able, in the struggle against fate.

According to the particular personal demand and the way in which the demand is [12] carried through, we characterize the struggle as: the *civil*, the *heroic*, and the *moral*.

The civil world is the world of finitude, of temporal goods. In a world built on sheer conditions, the rational will cannot then think of making any unconditional demand or requiring unconditional satisfaction. The finite goal is a tolerable condition: personality bows to circumstances, and comes to terms with fate. But the agreement that is thus concluded between the egoistic and the universal is nevertheless transient, unreliable, and false; the contracting parties are essentially each other's enemies: the tolerable condition soon becomes intolerable, and personality is driven to despair. The mighty oppress the lowly, and the lowly hate the mighty; the rich despise the poor, and the poor envy the rich; good fortune corrupts the fortunate, misfortune the unfortunate; corruption begets bitterness, bitterness breaks out in rebellion.

[13] When Cadmus sowed the dragon's teeth, there sprang up armored men, who slew one another: these armored men are the sons of fate.

Seen in the phenomenon, it is the rebellion of human beings against one another; seen essentially, it is the rebellion of finite, egoistic personality against fate. Seen in the phenomenon, it is an altered condition, a new order of things, that emerges from the struggle; seen essentially, it is the same condition, the same transient, unreliable, false agreement between the personal and the impersonal, the egoistic and the universal, thus still as before: the same fate.

In the civil tension between the selfish and the universal, personality must at once feel itself the weaker; which is why it also moves between the two extremes: pliant submissiveness and desperate insolence. If personality, on the other hand, feels itself as strong as the universal, the tension becomes passionately spiritual, and the struggle *heroic*.

[14] The heroic will is not content to receive conditions, it would itself prescribe conditions; it does not make do with a tolerable condition, it demands unconditional satisfaction. Here there is moreover a higher intermediary, in which the strained extremes, personality and fate, unite; this intermediary is the idea. The heroic will wills an idea, and insofar the universal; it also wills this idea realized in a determinate worldly goal, thus in a finitude: here fate lurks. By marking out its goal for itself, personality measures itself against fate. That fate has a superior power is at once evident; but instead of giving in, the will nevertheless prescribes to this superior power its conditions, in that it prescribes to itself a choice. This choice is between All and Nothing, the attainment of the goal and the downfall of personality.

"Whatever it cost, I go to the goal!" with this watchword freedom has raised itself above fate; so a Croesus interprets the oracle, so a Wallenstein reads in the stars, so a

Caesar crosses the Rubicon, and so begins the struggle.

It is the attainment of the goal that gives the personal its worth; therein lies “that, when the goal is taken away, personality is in itself something wholly indifferent; the [15] heroic resolution thus expresses the contradiction that the personal proves its highest validity by setting itself as a means for the goal, as that which is in itself indifferent. If this contradiction dawned on consciousness in a clear and sudden thought, it would be like a dagger thrust that instantly killed the hero; but the contradiction is veiled by the idea, is sensed as unrest in the mind, and transforms itself into a driving wheel of events. Permeated by the idea, the personal self-feeling is lost in the impersonal. The hero is most himself when he is most outside himself in his irresistible longing toward the goal; seized by an inexplicable power, he feels himself powerful; this feeling of power is his initiation, his mystical covenant with fate.

It is the cunning of fate to catch the personal by personality itself, as it is the pleasure of fate to trample its captive underfoot. Fate beguiles in the form of good fortune; it paralyzes as the riddle that awakens dread; it strikes in the shape of Nemesis; the beguiled Croesus, the paralyzed Wallenstein, the crushed Caesar.

In the heroic struggle the fusion of the personal with the impersonal is a mystery. [16] To unveil this mystery is a task for “the wise man.” Personality turns inward upon itself, in order to clarify and realize its free determination; thus the struggle becomes moral.

In order to measure itself against fate, personality must first of all give an account to itself of what it is that really stands in our power, and what all that signifies which does not stand in our power.

If it is now seen that the distribution of temporal goods and evils: health and sickness, riches and poverty, civil freedom and civil bondage, etc., does not essentially stand in our power, then liberation must begin with this, that the difference between temporal goods and temporal evils is reduced to a difference indifferent in itself.

To “the wise man,” then, it is wholly indifferent whether he is healthy or sick, rich or poor, master or slave. Certainly it is more pleasant to be healthy than to be sick; but since the will can prove its strength just as well in sickness as in health, the difference between the pleasant and the unpleasant cannot touch the personal self. [17]

To put up with the unpleasant and to accommodate oneself to adversity is resignation.

Already the civil struggle makes resignation necessary. He who craves temporal goods must put up with temporal losses; but it is only finite resignation where the

loss of the one is compensated by the attainment of the other. Thus in finitude fear and hope, sorrows and joys, loss and compensation alternate; even the loss of loved ones, however painful it may be at the moment, can be overcome, compensated — with time; for time heals all wounds.

This consolation of finitude, this temporal alternation of fear and hope, of the misery of the moment and the jubilation of the moment, “the wise man” despises. Raised in calm, proud self-feeling above the changeable, he resigns, not now and then with regard to this or that finite thing, but once for all with regard to everything finite, in that he recognizes that the temporal by its concept is and must be temporal, the perishable perishable.

[18] “If you have” — says the wise man — “a beautiful earthen vessel, remember well that it can be broken. If you forget this, it will painfully disturb you when it happens; but if you always remember it, chance cannot surprise you. If you love your wife and your son, then bear in mind that they are mortal. If you forget this, the pain may one day confuse your mind; but if you always remember it, you will calmly, without sigh or lament, follow them to the grave.”

What, then, is fate? In its phenomena an arbitrary play of prosperity and adversity, good luck and bad luck, but according to its essence that which is grounded in the nature of things, the necessary, the universally rational. From this is derived the moral law, that the ethical personality must will nothing other than what reason wills, and wish for nothing other than what follows from the course of things.

“You shall not weep when you sit in the theater and see a tragedy; for it is not sorrowful that the hero falls, if it is necessary. What must happen ought to happen, and with that you shall be content.”

[19] Devoting himself to the service of necessity, will the personal self transform necessity into freedom and make freedom irresistible as necessity. Thus reconciled with the laws of existence, the wise man says: “lead me, O Fate!”

In order to act in the world the will must set itself a worldly goal; but here is the difference between “the wise man” and “the fool.” The fool makes his personality a means for the goal; the wise man makes every finite goal a means for his personality.

“The world,” says the wise man, “is a great theater. Human beings are actors. The Deity is the poet who has the play performed, and distributes the roles. So the one gets the king’s, the other the beggar’s, the one the master’s, the other the slave’s role. It is not for the actor to reject his role, but to play his role. Only he who plays his role well wins the applause of the Deity.”

The Deity whose applause the wise man craves is, in the proper sense, personified Fate; the moral self is the personification of Fate. Infinite resignation is thus after all [20] an infinite egoism; it is the actor who on his own authority has composed for himself a role; it is the actor who plays for himself, and pleases himself in the role; it is the actor who in the end reaps his own applause.

That this is so without exaggeration is plainly seen in the last act.

The fateful personality, which here has made itself its own deity, cannot prove its self-will more plainly than by this, that it is master of its own life, and therefore itself chooses and determines its own death. The personal life is finite; the finite is indifferent. With freedom and deliberation the friend of Fate carries out what Fate would otherwise force upon him: he takes his own life. Personality asserts itself by annihilating itself. Herewith the moral struggle and the moral drama end.

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B. **On Providence.**

What Is Man?

Yes, what is man? Something great and glorious; something paltry and wretched! There is on earth no creature that can become as happy as a human being; for there is on earth no creature that can become as unhappy as a human being; none that can rejoice as a human being, because none can grieve as a human being; none that can fear what a human being can fear, because there is none that can hope as a human being can hope; none that can hate as a human being, because there is none that can love as a human being; none that can be arrogant as a human being; none that can humble himself as a human being; none that can mock as a human being; none that can worship as a human being; none, none that can suffer the wrong a human being can suffer; none, none that can do the wrong a human being can do to himself and others. What, then, is man?

All the helpless who are in the power of nature are helped by nature; man is in [22] the power of fate: who helps man?

Providence Revealed.

I.

For he maketh his sun to rise on the evil and on the good, and sendeth rain on the just and on the unjust.

But is that then a help? Can the good man console himself that the sun rises also on the evil? Can the just man rejoice that heaven blesses the unjust? We know that it goes thus in the world; we know that the laws of nature recognize no difference between evil and good, between just and unjust. The storm rises, and the ship sinks, and the human beings perish; they perish, both evil and good, both just and unjust. The earth opens and swallows the city, and the human beings are destroyed; they are destroyed, both evil and good, both just and unjust. The plague passes through the [23] lands, and human beings die of the deadly sickness; they die, both evil and good, both just and unjust. Can such a thing then signify a providence? It looks very much like fate.

Yes, if everything personal is finite, and the eternal itself impersonal, then it is fate. But if the personal is at the same time the eternal, if true personality is the truth of the eternal: then there is a providence.

If the eternal personality were not itself human, there would be for man no providence and no help; if man of himself were the eternal personality, then every human being would be his own providence and in the eternal sense his own helper.

Every human being who must confess: "I am not the truth, but I need the truth personally," must relate himself in faith to providence, and cannot be his own providence.

Only the human being who dared to say of himself: "Before Abraham was, I am, the truth of the eternal, the true personality," only such a human being can relate himself knowingly to providence, can as a human individual be under providence, and yet be Providence itself, who makes himself the object of faith.

[24] The Son of Man, who knew within himself that he was the true providence revealed in flesh and blood, and therefore made himself the object of faith, has accordingly not taught us to see the justice of providence in a finite distribution of temporal goods and temporal evils.

To pay for the temporal with the eternal, the eternal with the temporal, is for all eternity unjust; but to pay for the temporal with the temporal, the eternal with the eternal, that is like for like, that is divine justice.

If it were really the thought of Providence that good and evil should be requited temporally, should we not then expect that he who became man solely in order to be the revealed Providence would receive riches and power and all other temporal goods? Since this now does not happen: what can be the reason? Might Providence perhaps envy a human being the temporal? Or might he who is the true man set a kind of honor in doing without and despising what is human? That would be a mockery of everything divine and human. When he, then, who could have all the glory of the world, does not have anything on which he can lay his head, this abasement is not to [25] be ascribed to an arbitrariness of the will, any more than to a necessity of fate. It is human self-denial for the sake of truth, it is the infinite self-affirmation of personality, which in this lowliness reveals the divine superiority, the perfect justice.

For millennia now humanity has struggled for temporal requital; and still the sun rises on the evil and the good, and still it rains on the just and the unjust. He who looks at the course of the world in worldly fashion sees in all this only fate; but he who looks in faith at the Son of Man sees the will of the Father, who is in heaven.

If it were the thought of Providence that everyone who struggles for a universally valid idea should be recognized by human beings, and be vindicated in proportion to the worth of the idea and the power of sacrifice with which he struggles: should we not then expect that He who not only struggled for the highest idea, but was the idea itself, would have won for himself the highest recognition in the world?

All the great misunderstood, who otherwise have struggled for ideas, and have [26] been by their contemporaries rewarded with ingratitude, hatred, and contempt, could yet demand only a conditional recognition; it was yet only relative ideas for which they struggled; and even if one struggled for the highest, he could yet not say with truth: "I, who struggle for the highest, am myself the highest."

The Son of Man, who struggles for the eternal truth, bears witness of himself: "I am the truth"; the Son of Man can therefore make himself the object of faith, can demand unconditional submission, divine reverence.

All the great misunderstood, who otherwise can complain of human ingratitude, must yet admit that their contemporaries, by denying them recognition in the name of the idea, harm only themselves to a certain degree; the idea after all comes sometime to the benefit of the race: the individual's personality is indifferent.

The Son of Man, who is personality itself, and must demand unconditional recognition for the sake of personality, knows with irrefutable and painful certainty that every human being who denies him what he demands inflicts upon himself an eternal

personal wrong.

[27] All the great misunderstood, who otherwise were put in the wrong although they were in the right, could with reason complain of fate; and we, who now see the wrong they had to suffer, we can lament them, indeed we can weep over them, when we think of their fate. But He, the One, who was put in the wrong, not although but because he was in the right, eternally, unconditionally in the right, he will not be lamented, not pitied, not wept over; he says expressly: "Weep not over me, but weep over your own and your children's fate."

So the just one was among the unjust; the sun rose on the evil and the good, and as the sun sank, darkness rose on the good and the evil; and the darkness strengthened the evil, and in an hour of darkness the just one suffered for the unjust. It looks like a fate; yet it is not fate, it is the Father's will, who is in heaven.

If it were the thought of Providence that human beings themselves should find the way by the light of reason, then the Son of Man would never have made himself the object of faith.

Only like is recognized by like, the personal by the personal, but the personalities [28] of God and man are not each other's equals.

"Honor your friend, despise your enemy; procure for yourself justice in time, if you can, for in eternity no legal proceedings are held; good and evil, right and wrong are only differences of finitude, personal oppositions, which are all dissolved in the eternal, impersonal One." Here is the wisdom that denies Providence and deifies fate.

"Love your friend, hate your enemy; for your friends are the friends of the Eternal, your enemies the enemies of the Eternal: see, the sword is in your hand, that the justice of heaven may be fulfilled on earth." Here is the passion that would transform Providence itself into a fate.

The imagined superior power of personality is in both forms an eternal impotence. He who despises his enemy essentially despises himself; for he despises the personal: the superior power of contempt is an impotence of egoism. He who makes his enemy God's enemy rages against God: the fanatical superior power is a frenzied impotence.

[29] In order to save human personality from its natural impotence, Providence itself came in the form of a servant. Had he come in the form of a ruler with outward divine superior power, we should have remained in our natural impotence. But he denied himself, let the world keep the outward superior power, and became obedient unto death, that in self-denial and obedience he might reveal the infinite superiority of personality. His enemies were certainly God's enemies; he saw their blindness,

he grieved over the hardness of their hearts; but he did not despise them, he did not curse them: he prayed for them, and died.

Ye have heard that it hath been said: "Thou shalt love thy friend, and hate thine enemy"; but I say unto you: "Love your enemies, bless them that curse you, do good to them that hate you, and pray for them which despitefully use and persecute you, that ye may be the children of your Father who is in the heavens. *For he maketh his sun to rise on the evil and on the good, and sendeth rain on the just and on the unjust.*

[30]

II.

Yea, even all the hairs of your head are numbered; fear ye not therefore.

But are these words not to be understood as a poetic exaggeration? If divine justice is really exalted above every temporal difference between good and evil, is it then conceivable that the Eternal should sink so deep into the temporal and be so exacting about the particular? Is it conceivable that the Providence of mankind should count all the children of men, as a shepherd counts his sheep? Is it worthy of the All-Knowing to count so pettily, even the sparrows, even the hairs on the head of man?

"All the hairs of your head are numbered, fear ye therefore **not!**" If these words were only human words, we should have to regard them as an exaggeration in an outburst of enthusiasm; for in the world of dangers that lies between man and God, a human being has much to fear. But when He who speaks the Word is the Word itself, then we must learn from him where the danger is, and what we have to fear.

There is in the world of dangers only one unconditional danger, only One that is fearful, only One who is to be feared. Therefore the Word, the revealed Providence, says: "I will show you whom ye shall fear." [31]

And Providence is human. He who speaks of the danger, and shows us whom we shall fear; He who surveys all the dangers of finitude and says: "fear not!" he knows what danger is; his life was familiar with danger. Danger sought him in his cradle; it followed him to his grave. Everywhere, in the desert as in the cities, on the plains of Galilee, among the mountains of Judea, everywhere he went, danger went after him, and lay in wait for him.

Watchful as Providence, courageous as he who is under Providence, the Son of Man goes along the way of dangers, and fears nothing in the world. He works, and

nothing stops him; he goes to his goal, and no one lays a hand on him until his hour comes.

But when his hour had come he went voluntarily to meet danger; it did not surprise him as an accident, it did not come upon him as a fate; it came because he let
[32] it come. Nor did it come in outward uproar, not in a storm of human passions, not in a clamor of hostile weapons; it came in all stillness, alone to the Alone: only thus did he let it come.

Alone that night in the quiet garden, he let danger come to him, and struggled with it, not as the strong struggle, but as the frail, so that in flesh and blood there should not be a difference of fate between the strong and the frail, but a victory of devotion in frailty.

Alone that night in the quiet garden, he let danger pass as a mortal anguish through his soul; he did not defy it, he did not despise it, he did not proudly lift his head like him who sacrifices himself to fate; he fell on his face, and bowed himself humbly under the Father's will.

Alone that night in the quiet garden, he let all the dangers of finitude transform themselves in inwardness into one danger. So he struggled in inwardness, and conquered in inwardness; and when he then rose from the struggle, behold, then it was over with danger, then there was no danger at all.

[33] Yet — what do I say? Is it really over with danger: now the real danger first comes, for now the guard comes with swords and staves. Yes, now reality comes, but — the danger has turned. He who asks: "Whom seek ye?" is undismayed; the guard falls to the ground in dismay.

The night when the Son of Man was betrayed, scourged, and condemned, is in reality a night of dangers; but the danger has turned. Here is danger for a Judas; here is danger for a Caiaphas. Here is danger for a Pilate, who washes his hands; here is danger for the people, that the blood of the Innocent comes upon their head. Yes, here are many dangers and for many; but for Him, the One, for him there is no danger.

Were there danger for him, he would surely get relief; were his life, his cause really in danger, his servants would surely fight for him, and more than twelve legions of angels arm themselves for his defense. Now he stands without defenders, weaponless, alone among his enemies: why? Because the danger is already over; because his hairs are numbered.

[34] "Not a sparrow falls to the ground without the Father's will; yea, even the hairs of your head are numbered."

The world of finitude is a world of contingencies. If now this or that accidental thing is held fast in its accidental singularity, then every such accidental singularity, as e.g. that a sparrow falls to the ground, that a hair falls from a human head, etc., is certainly indifferent to God and man. Such a holding fast of the accidental in its contingency is, namely, spiritless, and the spiritless is for all eternity indifferent.

The accidental first gains significance by being seen in an essential relation to an Other that is not accidental. This Other can again be: either the rational ground of the world or personality itself.

What contingency signifies in its connection with the ground of the world and natural causes is a scientific question, which does not at all concern faith in providence.

What contingency, on the other hand, signifies as a worldly matter between God and man, is a personal question. This question can be answered only by Him who [35] reveals the thought of Providence.

Here is one born blind; let us hear the Master's conversation with the disciples. "And the disciples asked him and said: Master, who hath sinned? this man or his parents, that he is born blind? And the Master said: neither this man sinned, nor his parents; but that the works of God should be made manifest on him."

The disciples and the Master are thus agreed in the presupposition that chance cannot be anything independent in relation to God, that Providence in every accident removes the accidental. But in that the disciples simply overlook chance, they are entangled in a double misunderstanding, inasmuch as they at once fail to recognize the reality of natural conditions, and drag divine justice down into the temporal. The Master, who knows the thought of Providence, calls attention to the difference between natural determination and God's express will. The difference between the sighted and those born blind is a natural difference in the temporal, which does not directly correspond to God's retributive justice. Insofar the accidental is thus conceded. But the accidental is not for God in its contingency; it is determined as a [36] means for his determinate purpose. What was therefore the case with that man born blind, that the works of God should be made manifest on him, the same is just the case with all those born blind and with all the possible accidents in the world that concern the personal.

— "As long as I am in the world, I am the light of the world."

The natural man, who sees everything in the light of naturalness, sees accident upon accident, both in the course of the world and in his own life; it is the congenital blindness in finite personality, which cannot see Providence for sheer accidents. The

Son of Man, the personal truth, opens the eyes of the blind, and thereby removes the sad accident.

“As long as I am in the world, I am the light of the world.”

The history of Providence is a sacred history. If sacred history were to be grasped directly, like any other history, then we would only need to follow the Son of Man on
[37] his way, in order to see how he abolishes contingency and reveals the work of God. But in the sacred history of Providence the outer is so dissimilar to the inner that only he who sees everything in the light of faith sees Providence.

The richer the sources of help that personality has in itself, the more easily it transforms the accident into means and occasion; the more surprising the accident is, the more surprising also is the presence of mind that flashes through contingency. Therefore genius is in league with fortune, is itself fortune; therefore practical genius counts as many victories as decisive accidents.

If now the personal superiority that reveals the thought of Providence were to be compared with the superiority of genius: then we should invite the spirited, the geniuses, to go through the sacred history; then we should say to these spirited, these geniuses: “Look for once rightly at the Son of Man; as he masters contingency, no one on earth has yet been able to master it; for to him nothing is accidental, he abolishes and transforms all accidents. Is it the manifold cases of illness; he removes
[38] every accident, for he heals all the sick. Is it the sad cases of death; he removes them, when and where he will, for he can raise the dead. Is it one of malice’s intriguing, ingeniously contrived accidents, an accident like that with the tribute money, or an accident like that with the woman and her seven husbands in the resurrection; behold, he masters all these contingencies. The lightning of truth splits the web of malice, and the accident falls like a fate on those who harden themselves in untruth.

But although the personal omnipotence in all these cases is unmistakable, such a conception is in itself a blasphemy; the Son of Man is not a hero of fortune; he is the Holy One of Providence, the object of faith. — “Believest thou that I can do this?” —

If you do not believe, the accident remains in its sad contingency; but “if thou wouldest believe, thou shouldest see the glory of God.” — “As long as I am in the world, I am the light of the world.”

To the fate-born blind all finite accidents are indifferent. With this everything
[39] particular is dissolved in a uniform, impersonal, empty generality that lacks the content of life and the richness of colors. “The wise man” with all his strength is therefore also like a spiritual shadow-image, a specter of Fate, that dwindles into the

dim.

For him who “believes in the Son of God,” the personal truth, the true personality, the worldly accidental is a personal matter between God and the individual human being. Every accident that meets one is a particular task which Providence sets for personal solution: as many accidents, as many tasks. In the finite solution possibility stands against possibility, understanding against misunderstanding, danger against danger: — Man, do what you will, but do it in unconditional faith! If you do not believe, it will be for you a sad accident, but — “if thou wouldest believe, thou shouldest see the glory of God.”

— “As long as I am in the world, I am the light of the world.”

The outwardly changing manifold of finite accidents is, when seen in the light of truth, sheer particular conditions for the development of the personal inner being. [40] The accidents of life are God’s dispensations. Unbelief, which in the dispensation sees only chance, falls to fate; faith, which in every accident sees the dispensation, is saved by Providence.

Man’s relation to the Providence revealing itself in the sacred history is therefore not a uniform, colorless relation that loses itself in impersonal generality; it is an infinitely rich in content, manifold life-relation, nuanced to the smallest details, between the personal truth and human personalities. Here in every scene faith stands against unbelief, the sighted against the blind; here the blind become seeing, the sighted blind; here every event, every accident, every word, every glance, indeed every moment has the significance of infinity; here the light rises on evil and good; here the dispensation comes upon the just and the unjust; here the works of God are made manifest; here the thoughts of many hearts are made manifest.

— “As long as I am in the world, I am the light of the world.”

In the highest tension between wisdom’s plan, the arbitrariness of men and the world’s contingencies, Providence is revealed; therefore the sacred history is a history of sufferings. [41]

In the history of suffering it looks as if Fate itself would rise up to battle against Providence, as if contingency were to rule, and human arbitrariness tear itself loose from governance.

And in the history of suffering it looks as if God’s will had eternally predetermined each single event, each single scene, each single trait.

— So the One must “die for the people, that the whole people perish not.” It is a notion of malice, a despotic arbitrariness of an individual in a single accident; and yet,

— it is no arbitrariness, it is an inspiration of the Spirit, it is a prophecy that expresses the thought of Providence. — So the Just One is “reckoned among malefactors”; — an outrageous, sad arbitrariness, a sad accident! and yet, it is no arbitrariness; it is the foreordained counsel of wisdom, it is the fulfillment of prophecy.

[42] So the Crucified One dies: the sun is darkened, the veil is rent, the graves burst.... “marvelous occurrences, perhaps invented accidents”.... Yes, but — if thou wouldst believe!

Are not two sparrows sold for a farthing, and not one of them falls to the ground without your Father’s will. Yea, even all the hairs of your head are numbered. Fear ye not therefore, ye are better than many sparrows.

III.

With God All Things Are Possible.

But no miracles happen after all! — “Yes, that is just the disquieting thing, that a personality who belongs to the age of wonders is here presented as a model, that He who performs the many wondrous deeds is just to be an example for us, who live under the laws of nature. He who can still the storm may well sleep in the ship; but he who cannot still the storm must watch and use his strength. He who with a word can cast the guard to the ground can easily put the sword into its sheath; but when [43] the word can do nothing, one must try the naked steel.”

If these misgivings belonged merely to declared unbelief, we should pay no heed to them; but where is a faith so strong that it does not struggle with doubt?

Most human beings surely know such moments of sorrow, of anxiety, of tension, in which the thought as if involuntarily forces itself upon them: Oh, that a miracle might happen after all!

— “He hath saved others, himself he cannot save.” So sounded the mocking word over Him who had helped so many, and now was himself as one helpless.

All help in the temporal is in the thought of Providence a means for the eternal: help can be given by a miracle; but help can also be given without a miracle. If the miracle is understood as a help in the temporal, then it does not help at all; it harms. If helplessness in the temporal is understood as a means of awakening for the eternal, then it does not harm at all; it helps. That a miracle happens can be both for help and for ruin; that the miracle does not happen can be both for ruin and [44] for help. A human being is helped by God only when he is helped unconditionally personally; but he is helped unconditionally personally only when he is helped to

faith, in faith, by faith. Why has the miracle happened? That I shall believe. Why does the miracle not happen? That I shall believe. He who denies the possibility of the miracle denies Providence; he who assumes that God can help only by a miracle also denies Providence.

As a sign of his divine omnipotence the Son of Man performs the miracle: he feeds the hungry. But — is it not wonderful? — He who helps others by a miracle does not help himself by a miracle. He who was able to feed five thousand in the wilderness did not, however, turn stones into bread to still his own hunger in the wilderness.

Here is seen the two-sidedness of Providence's help. The solitary hungry one, who is tempted to a miracle, and yet will not help himself by a miracle, is nevertheless essentially helped: he has the help personally in himself; he has the help in the divine certainty that a human being is not helped in one way, but in countless ways, because "man doth not live by bread alone, but by every word that proceedeth out of the mouth [45] of God."

The hungry multitude, which is helped by the miracle, is nevertheless essentially helpless. It hungers again the next day, and seeks the Helper, not because it saw the sign, but because it ate of the bread and was filled. The help was offered, and yet it could not help; because the hungry believed that bread alone was at stake, because the multitude believed that help was to be given temporally in the temporal.

With God all things are possible. In countless ways Providence can help; and yet it is all in vain when man will not understand the eternal, personal help, and let himself be helped. If help could be given temporally in the temporal, then surely all the hungry would soon be filled, all the naked clothed, and all the sorrows of finitude ended; here are five thousand who can bear witness that Providence both can and will help; but here are also five thousand who can bear witness that this is not the help.

With God all things are possible. In a supernatural way Providence can reveal its dominion over life and death. If the healing of the sick and the resurrection of the dead were the help itself: then omnipotence would surely quickly heal all the sick, and open all graves; but when it is a matter of the perishable personality's transformation into imperishability, help can be given only by inward healing, inward awakening. That the miracle happens becomes, in the revelation of Providence, precisely a proof that the miracle in and for itself is not the help, and thereby at the same time a proof that the means of help can just as well consist in this, that no miracles happen.

With God all things are possible. As a sign of his divine omnipotence the Son of Man performs a wonder of awakening. But — is it not strange after all? — He who

knows within himself that he can wake the dead man from the grave, behold, he stands like a helpless one grieved at the grave and weeps.

To be able to raise the dead man and yet stand and weep at the grave looks like a contradiction. Yes, certainly, no one who will use his understanding can deny that here there must be a contradiction. But whose is the blame? who is it that here causes [47] the contradiction? Not the Helper, but the many helpless, who by him are to be helped. If the helpless could at once see in what the help consists, then there would be help enough here, then He who stands at the grave could in a moment save all, and glorify himself. But the help is misunderstood, the means is transformed; what ought to have been for the Helper's glorification brings precisely persecution and suffering upon him, makes him, humanly speaking, helpless; this is precisely the contradiction, and a contradiction so sad that the Son of God himself must weep over it.

"He hath saved others, himself he cannot save." — How there can be truth in a blasphemy! For it is literally true that he hath saved others, and it is also literally true that he now cannot save himself — by the miracle.

Had the means of help been the help itself; had lie and malice, violence and injustice been capable of being annihilated by a miracle: then the sacred history of Providence would not have become a history of sufferings, but a history of glorification for God and men. Now, on the contrary, since the miracle is only a means, and the [48] means is perverted, help is given by the opposite means, so that help is given in all inwardness by this, that no miracle happens. In order to help personally the personal Helper must himself become like the helpless one. — "And will all then be helped?"

With men this is impossible, but with God all things are possible.

C.

On Fate and Providence.

I.

Fate Is Guilt.

Because that which may be known of God is manifest to them, for God hath shewed it unto them, — so that they are without excuse.

He who would trust in the help of Providence must do the will of Providence; he who would do the will of Providence must know the thought of Providence. Who knows the thought of Providence? Who does the will of Providence? The personal truth, the true personality.

The relation between the One, who is the personal truth, and the many, who [49] through him are to be made partakers of the truth, is not an external historical relation between a solitary individual who once existed, and a multitude of other individuals who in time have joined together about this One. Were it so, there would be a difference of fate between those who were so fortunate as to enter into a personal relation to the extraordinary individual, and the many, many who were lawfully excused for not knowing him, because they had never seen him, and never heard a word about him.

The personal truth is the King of truth; everyone who loves the truth hears his voice, and everyone who hears his voice is saved by Providence.

All fate is personal untruth; for fate comes only by the personal itself making itself into the untrue. All fate is essentially guilt; for fate comes only by the personal wronging itself by bowing under the impersonal. All fate is essentially sin; for fate arises only by man's denying God by transforming him into something impersonal. [50]

The immediate self-feeling of personality is determined partly by the finite, partly by the eternal. The self-feeling, immediately determined by the finite, is egoism; determined by the eternal, it is conscience.

The ideal of egoism is a mixture of the personal with the impersonal; this mixture is the veiled, in which the finite personality hides its impotence from itself; this veiled is the mythical. It is not merely the idol that is mythical; the mythical is in the idolater's impersonal personality.*)

The ideal of conscience is a unity of revelation and faith. In revelation the egoistic impotence becomes manifest to itself in the face of the personal omnipotence, and in faith man receives the power of his true personality as a power of God.

All ideals of egoism stand under fate; all ideals of conscience are under Providence. [51]

Throughout the whole of history the struggle goes on between personal truth and personal untruth, between the ideals of egoism and of conscience. In the course of the struggle the race divides asunder, and the movement parts into two currents: the

*)The *mythical* is not a determination of fantasy; it is an ethical determination. The mythical interpretation of the Old as well as of the New Testament is grounded in personal untruth, or, if one will, in impersonal truth.

mythical, and that which in faith in revelation is *religious*.

In the mythical direction the ideals of egoism prevail amid ceaseless counteractions of conscience; in the believing direction conscience prevails amid ceaseless counteractions of egoism. The separation is thoroughgoing, like a separation between two opposed spheres of spirit. Over both there is a fate, for in both there is a guilt; but also over both there is a Providence that has compassion, and punishes the guilt.

For the people of the myths the punishment is fate; for the people of revelation fate is punishment; both are led to the goal: the personal truth is the goal of Providence, and the goal is reached in the fullness of time.

[52] In the fullness of time, then, the realized ideal of conscience appears: *saving*, for the salvation of personality is the concern of conscience; *judging*, for every human being shall be judged by his ideal. But the truth of the ideal is the King of truth; every gleam of personal truth, every spark of conscience that manifests itself in the world is a spark of his flame, a gleam of his light.

The personal truth is the King of truth; everyone who loves the truth hears his voice, and recognizes that he is the ideal itself. But those who remain in untruth do not hear his voice; they prefer to keep their own self-made, distorted ideals, the one in nature, the other in the written law. Now the guilt becomes manifest. The offense now lies not in the ideal's having been obscured and distorted in the course of the ages; for this distortion is surely removed precisely by the King of truth himself appearing in the world; no, the offense lies just in this, that each of the parties in his own way wants to keep the distorted ideal, the ideal that contradicts conscience but
[53] flatters egoism. Thus the misapprehension of Providence becomes open rebellion against Providence; such a rebellion is a blindness, the blindness is fate, fate is guilt: here no excuse holds.

If truth is posited as impersonal, then what the modern spirit asserts is quite correct, namely that the history of the human race is sinless, and that sins fall upon all individuals without exception; but if the personal truth is acknowledged, then the word of faith holds, that the history of the race is a sinful history, and that there is One in the race who is sinless.

The history of the world is in unceasing rebellion against Providence; but the governance shows itself in this, that the rebels are impotent. In order to see the rebellion in its whole extent we must distinguish between the noisy rebels and the silent rebels.

In a picture of the spirit the noisy rebels are depicted from ancient days as the

peoples that “rage and imagine a vain thing, as the mighty ones of the earth who would break asunder the bands of governance and strive against the King of Providence.” Against these the strong word is used, that He who sitteth in the heavens shall laugh.

The punishment that is to strike these rebels comes accordingly also in the shape [54] of fate; for the King of Providence shall “break them with a rod of iron, as a potter’s vessel shall he dash them in pieces.”

The noisy rebels are outwardly recognizable precisely because they make noise; it is otherwise with the silent ones. The silent rebels do not boldly raise ideal against ideal; they do not lift their heads so high that fate can historically strike them: who, then, are the silent rebels?

Let us first confess that the silent rebellion smoulders in us all, and further characterize the rebels themselves according to the concept. They are surely all those who trust in the assistance of Providence without ever putting to themselves the serious question: what then, really, is the thought of Providence? they are surely all those who confidently appeal to truth and right, without however being willing to bow unconditionally before the ideal of justice, and to hear the King of truth; they are surely all those human beings, high and low, rich and poor, gifted and ungifted, who solely and alone, or at least chiefly and most immediately, arrange their lives for cozy well-being, agreeable security, finite busyness, temporal activity for temporal purposes, and for the rest are all virtue-adorned, in so far as they are all adorned with [55] the virtues most necessary for earthly well-being, such as: respectability, decency, industriousness, sobriety, honesty in money matters, peaceableness, obligingness, to which may further be reckoned good-naturedness, affability, sociability, etc., all these, who have all these virtues and neither more nor less, all these are neither more nor less than honnête, decent, quiet, respectable rebels against the eternal thought of Providence, against the King of truth who humbled himself, and let the dispensations come over him, that it might yet become manifest what it is to know the thought of Providence and to do the will of Providence.

II.

Temporal Conditions.

The Lord maketh poor, and maketh rich: he bringeth low, and lifteth up.

The inequality in human conditions is indeed in a worldly sense to be regarded as a sorrowful disproportion, an injustice of fate; but in the sense of faith this inequality is just a proof of the omnipresent justice of Providence. [56]

In a temporal respect the rich man has an extraordinary favoring above the poor man, the mighty above the lowly; in the language of worldliness we must express this thus: Fate is he who maketh poor, and who maketh rich; it is he who *bringeth low*, and who lifteth up.

If, on the other hand, we see the matter in the light of faith, then there is in this no injustice at all, no arbitrariness, no partiality. That this is not an arbitrary assertion but an eternal truth follows directly from the opposition between the worldly and the religious.

In relation to fate, that is, in worldliness, man's significance is in every respect made finite. A human being can be something great in the world; but all worldly greatness is relative: even the greatest individuality vanishes as an insignificance in the immeasurable whole. Conversely a human being can be something very lowly; but even the lowliest is yet always Something. As now all greatness and all lowliness in [57] the worldly sense is piecework, so is all of man's significance piecework: worldliness is just the parceled-out human being.

It is not the same man who is at once both great and lowly; rather the one is great, the other lowly; it is not the same man who is at once both rich and poor; rather the one is rich, the other poor; indeed the same man is not even always the same: formerly he was mighty, now he is merely lowly; formerly he was poor, now he is rich.

If now this worldly parceling-out of the human being is held fast in its worldliness, then we have fate. Every human being who has his life in this parceling-out expresses personally the impersonal truth: Fate is he who maketh poor, and who maketh rich; it is he who *bringeth low*, and who lifteth up.

In the face of God, on the other hand, man in his finitude is "dust and ashes," an indifferent magnitude, a pure nothing; and yet man is in God's thought something infinitely great, spirit of God's spirit, God's image. Here the finite, the relative, falls away on both sides, and with it the parceling-out too falls away.

[58] Here the same man is essentially always the same. The same man who here is lowly is also great, for his greatness issues from his lowliness; the same man who here is poor is also rich, for in his poverty there is born personally a richness of eternity.

But now the piecework, the world and worldliness? Worldliness must go; but the world remains, for the world is good; the piecework remains, for this piecework is very good — in the eyes of Providence.

The Lord maketh poor, and maketh rich; he *bringeth low*, and lifteth up.

All dispensations are personal tasks. By means of the piecework the one task becomes many tasks, and precisely in this difference for each human being a really true and personal task.

What in each dispensation is divine help is at the same time temporal burden, and everything that looks like temporal help is conversely divine burden.

If we set the mighty man and the lowly man over against each other, then the task comes in wholly opposite dispensations, and, so to speak, under two disguises. Each [59] of the two receives immediately the personal impression of existence that corresponds to his position: a human being is something great; a human being is something lowly.

If now the solution of the task consisted merely in an appropriation of the personal impression that a human being is something great, and can accomplish something great in the world: then the mighty man would be arbitrarily favored, for that impression he receives precisely from all sides at every moment that he lives.

If conversely the solution of the task consisted in an immediate appropriation of the impression that a human being is something lowly; then the lowly man would be directly favored by his lowliness, for the world will surely teach him how lowly he is.

But — here the same man is essentially always the same. The solution of the task therefore consists for both in a working-up and inward appropriation of both impressions; thereby the conditions become equal.

Can now the mighty man work up the impression of worldly greatness in such a way that he — not merely for edification in a quiet hour, but in all worldly surroundings, in real personality — at every moment transforms this impression into a religious feeling of infinite lowliness before God; can the mighty man, when thousands look up [60] to him with admiration, yet always see the eye that looks down upon him testingly: then he solves a great task; then he understands that temporal help is divine burden; then he will also bear his burden, remain in the height, and lift up his head as one who is set in the height, elucidating the thought that the Lord is he who lifteth up.

Next comes the lowly man, but — how great, how exalted is not his task! What he is, what he feels, thinks and does, is after all so insignificant, for the whole so indifferent, that no one takes notice of it, because it is not worth noticing at all. And yet this insignificant man and all the insignificant things he does shall be of infinite significance. For him who is not even known in the world every moment shall be just as important, just as exciting, just as decisive as for him who is placed so high that his beck moves a world. If now the lowly man can solve this task, if he, the unnoticed, can really appropriate the personal impression that in every instant he is noticed

[61] by Providence: then he will truly understand that that which is temporal burden is divine help; then, if it is to be so, he will gladly remain in lowliness as the oppressed: he is not, after all, oppressed by fate; he expresses the thought that the Lord is he who bringeth low.

If now we place the mighty man alongside the lowly man, as they have both placed themselves under Providence; then the first will surely not despise the last, and the last not envy the first; no, now they will understand one another in all inwardness, and help one another with all their strength, the mighty man by his might, the lowly man by his lowliness.

“The Lord maketh poor, and maketh rich.”

When the rich, in grateful acknowledgment of the wisdom of Providence, impress this sentence as a divine guarantee of the right of property, while the poor, in impatience over the arbitrariness of fate, rise up in order to come to the aid of wisdom: then the waters roar, then the rebels meet from both sides, the silent with the noisy; but — He that sitteth in the heavens shall laugh.

[62] It is in the common opinion an easy matter to thank Providence for riches, but very hard to have to thank it for poverty. This is, however, not the divine opinion. *The truth* says: “blessed are the poor”; the truth says: “it is easier for a camel to go through the eye of a needle than for a rich man to enter into the kingdom of God.” If then what *the truth* says is true, then riches must be a great and terrible burden; but if riches are so great and terrible a burden, then the rich man is surely not favored by God above the poor man.

What shall the poor man do? Understand God’s dispensation, and transform the burden into help.

What shall the rich man do? Understand the dispensation, and transform the burden into help. But then the rich man is to do the very same as the poor man. If now both are, each in his own way, to do the same; then they also need mutual support, and ought consequently to help one another; but above all the poor man ought to help the rich man, for the poor man surely has the less to bear.

[63] The poor man who is helped by God in such a way that he — in personal truth really helps the rich man, proves precisely thereby in deed that the Lord is he who maketh poor.

“It is easier for a camel to go through the eye of a needle than for a rich man to understand the thought of Providence and to do the will of Providence”; riches thus make the solution of the task so difficult that the burden must almost be regarded as

superhuman. What, then, is the personal counsel of the truth to the rich man? That the rich man as soon as possible lessen his superhuman burden, and help himself by helping the poor man. Only when the rich man thus helps the poor man, only when the rich man personally before God acknowledges that he, every time he relieves the need of the needy, essentially helps himself, does he express the truth that the Lord is he who maketh rich.

So the conditions are equal; so we are all, though under many disguises, children of one Father; so justice is divine, as God is just.

[64]

III.

Spiritual Conditions.

Every good and perfect gift cometh from above, from the Father of lights, with whom is no variableness, neither shadow of turning.

If anyone should ask outright whether the talents, the geniuses, the heroes and the great ideas of the world are not, in virtue of their higher nature, to be said in quite a peculiar sense to be under Providence; such a question cannot be answered so long as it is held in a generality that excludes the personal. Only when the personal is taken in does the question have meaning, and the answer will then depend on the position that personality takes up toward the ideas.

He who holds to the impersonal truth, that is, in this case — where the personal is precisely the decisive thing — to the personal untruth, will then naturally maintain that the ideas originate from the natural ground of the world-reason, and that the higher gifts of spirit are consequently nothing other than pure gifts of nature.

He, on the other hand, who believes personally in the personal truth will unconditionally hold fast the presupposition that every good and perfect gift cometh from [65] above, from the Father of lights, that thus the ideas in history, like the birds of the air, the geniuses in art, like the lilies of the field, stand under God's fatherly care.

The difference between the gifted and the ungifted is in a certain way comparable to the difference between the rich and the poor. The gifted are indeed the spiritually rich, who impart to us of their abundance what they can well spare. The inequality, however, acquires a quite different significance in the spiritual than in the temporal. Seen in the idea, nothing is so estimable as a true aristocracy of spirit, and seen in the idea, nothing is so contemptible as the mere aristocracy of money.

The spiritually gifted are destined to be the benefactors, teachers, educators and disciplinarians of the race; they are the servants of the idea, sent out to serve those who are to be made partakers of the riches of the ideas; but whichever of these servants we may choose for an example, we become convinced that every extraordinary gift
[66] transforms itself into a divine burden, when the gifted man is to express the thought of Providence.

For God every human work, even the greatest masterpiece, is nothing. For talent the work is everything; for it is indeed “the work that shall praise the master.” For God only the personal ideal of conscience counts; in the relative spheres of spirit the many impersonal ideals leading to the execution of works count. If now the gifted are to place themselves under Providence, then each of them will have to live for two ideals that counteract each other; for each of them then receives, besides the ideal of conscience, which makes the work a nothing, also the ideal corresponding to his talent, which makes the work everything. But to live for two ideals that strive against each other is extraordinarily burdensome.

That the superiority of the gifted over the ungifted is really a divine burden can be shown in examples from the various spheres of spirit.

Suppose the brilliant artist places himself under Providence beside the simple
[67] workman. They both then acknowledge the ideal of conscience; they are thus equal in religious enthusiasm. But the workman’s work lies so far below the ideal that it can in no way become the object of tempting enthusiasm; the artist’s labor, on the other hand, is impossible without a corresponding enthusiasm.

What a difference! While the workman only worships one God, and has only one enthusiasm, the artist almost gets two gods, in that he gets two ideals, and is enthused in two heterogeneous directions. While one will hardly find any workman who thinks that his work as work is to the glory of God (for it would be strange if anyone asserted that he could dig gravel to the glory of God, or slake lime to the glory of God), the artist is incessantly tempted to confound the demand of the ideal of art and that of the ideal of conscience. Yes, if only talent could succeed in transforming the worship of art into a direct worship of God, then the artist would be helped, then one could indeed say that the gifted man was the favorite both of fortune and of God. But it is impossible: aesthetic pietism is rebellion against Providence. No more can a
[68] picture be painted, be it a Catholic picture of Mary or a Protestant picture of Christ, to the glory of God, than an overture can be composed to the glory of God, or a comedy played to the glory of God.

All religious worship of art is refined idolatry. In art the work is everything; in the eyes of Providence the work is nothing. The separation of sacred and secular art is so far from marking a real difference between the religious and the profane in the personal sense, that the “sacred” art precisely brings with it the greatest temptation to profane the sacred. The difference is, to be sure, drawn from the subject matter, but yet chiefly from the inspiration of the talent. The profane artist (the dramatist, the actor) is inspired in a worldly way, and is not so easily tempted to confuse his muse with an angel of Providence; the “sacred” artist, on the other hand, gets his inspiration through the sacred objects, his enthusiasm for art is like an enthusiasm for God: so it easily happens that the enthused man becomes giddy, receives the prompting as a revelation of God, falls worshipping upon his knees, and becomes — a refined idolater.

Every extraordinary talent is a good and perfect gift; but it costs incredible exertion [69] to express the personal truth that the gift cometh from above.

The not-gifted man, who eats his bread in the sweat of his face, and sighs under the burdens of finitude, has in these burdens a divine help, and is not tempted by the relative ideals. The gifted man, who is moved in mood and surrenders himself in ideal productivity, must redouble his exertion in order to preserve his personality. The work, which is everything to him, must at the same time be to him a nothing, an indifferent thing, a child’s game, a vehicle for the development of ethical powers. The gifted man who can now do this: who can have art as though he had it not, can love its ideal as though he loved it not, because he loves God above all things, can thank God just as inwardly when the work utterly fails as when it succeeds beyond measure, can hold himself so unchanged to the ideal of conscience that in his personality there is not so much as shadow of turning, however fortune may change in the world of art; yes, the gifted man who can do this, he is truly a master over many masters; he knows what it means that the gift is more than a gift of fortune; he expresses personally the truth that the gift cometh from above, from the Father of lights, with whom is no variableness, neither shadow of turning. [70]

A life consecrated to art always has the possibility of much fortune and much misfortune, of bitter pains and of rich enjoyments; this holds directly, in so far as the gift is conceived as a gift of nature. Thus abandoned to a fantastic change of luck and ill luck, talent stands directly under fate.

If, however, the gifted man will place himself under Providence, then his life, regardless of fortune and misfortune, is essentially consecrated to ethical exertion and religious suffering. And what are then all the quackeries of finitude about luck

and ill luck, recognition and non-recognition in comparison with the inner personal exertion of having to work for a goal, an ideal, that is nevertheless a means, a nothing; of having to be kindled by enthusiasm, and then again to be enthused to quench the flame of enthusiasm!

If we now consider this, and bear in mind that the children of art are the servants
[71] of the idea, sent out to serve us; and consider what these servants must sacrifice for our sake, bear and suffer for our sake, then we surely have no cause to envy them their spiritual superiority; we are much more bound to serve them in turn in everything we can, to meet them with gratitude, and to honor them as the envoys of Providence, provided they really (as we must believe) strive in everything to express the thought of Providence.

If we look about us in the kingdom of truth, we find two wholly opposed spheres, that of science and that of personality. Scientific truth is in its essence impersonal; personal truth is in its essence unscientific.

In science talent counts; it is again the difference of finitude between the gifted and the ungifted that proves that science belongs to the world. In the sphere of personality this difference is removed. The truth says: "I thank thee, O Father, Lord of heaven and earth, that thou hast hid these things from the wise and prudent, and hast revealed
[72] them unto babes"; this says, after all, in other words: "I thank thee, Father, that thou hast made the personal truth unscientific."

The concepts fate and providence are themselves unscientific concepts; their difference shows itself only as personality steps in, and takes up its position.

If personality bows under the scientific truth, then the impersonal prevails, and then comes fate. With this position it is easy enough to dissolve the whole doctrine of faith into untruth; but by this position personality has at the same time essentially given itself up, and finds itself in personal untruth. Scientific truth has absolutely no guilt in this untruth: the guilt lies in the personal self.

If personality, on the other hand, asserts its original right, and turns believing to the object of faith: then it is a fairly easy matter to get rid of the scientific objections; for they fall away of themselves.

Let us then in the name of Providence acknowledge our religious relation to God as a personal relation; but let us then also, in the name of Providence, resist the
[73] temptation to want to have a "*science of faith*," or in other words: to want to have this personal element again interpreted in the impersonal.

All that can be done scientifically in order to clarify and secure the tasks of faith

consists in a complete and distinct separation of the boundaries of science and of personality. Every concept of faith must therefore be presented in such a way that it becomes recognizable precisely by its sharp opposition to the concept of knowledge, and the heterogeneity of the spheres demonstrated and elucidated at all points.

Such categories as “religious genius,” “scientific gift of grace,” belong to the offspring of fancy, which are neither religious nor scientific.

Genius is in its immediate form a gift of nature, and no gift of nature can relate itself directly as supporting the religious.

The religious moment is never scientific; the scientific moment is never religious.

It goes with the man of science as with the artist: if he would express the thought of Providence, he is drawn in two opposite directions. Science is his goal, his work, his worldly ideal. Working for this goal, he must use his whole power of consciousness in [74] order to remove everything personally disturbing and to forget himself in the interest of the universal truth. If he is then to return to the religious, he needs conversely his whole power of consciousness in order to collect himself personally, to rouse himself to an immediate sensation of the punctual impression of actuality, and to recognize that it is now not a matter of this or that in general, but that it concerns him, him himself personally before the personal God.

Scientificity does not further the religious, it stupefies the religious. He who sits in the deepest scientificity is as far from the religious as he who lies in the deepest sleep.

Here too it appears that worldly advantage is divine burden. It is far easier amid the occupations, sorrows and joys of everyday life to work inwardly in the religious than to have the religious in a study. You can carry a millstone, and have the religious; but no thinker on earth can have the religious at the moment he unties a scientific [75] knot. A woman can spin at her spinning wheel, and have the religious; but a man, were he ever so believing, cannot reason scientifically about God’s existence, and at the same time have the religious.

That all science in and for itself, like all that is worldly in and for itself, leads away from God, lies in this, that all science leads away from the personal. When the personal, the punctual in the ideal of conscience, is first duly weakened, the ideal of science can then also easily transform itself into the Godhead itself. Hence such phrases are heard as: “Science brings us nearer to God; the cultivation of science is in a higher sense the worship of God.”

But is science, then, not a good and perfect gift? Yes, truly! but it costs incredible

exertion, if the existence of the knower is to express the personal truth that the gift cometh from above, from the Father of lights, with whom is no variableness, neither shadow of turning.

The superiority of spirit is man's suffering: He who hath the eternal Spirit has suffered for us all.

[76] If we survey the distribution of the spiritual gifts as a whole, it shows itself, from two different sides: worldly unjust, divinely just.

The spirit of worldliness, the spirit of the relative ideals, of finite works and strivings, is impersonal, and for that very reason unjust. The gifts of nature are distributed indiscriminately like the gifts of fortune: the one is gifted, the other limited; the one completes a great work, and becomes something great; the other accomplishes nothing, and remains in insignificance. So the labors are divided: the gifted man gets the great labor, and is at an advantage; the ungifted man must stand back. So the laborers contend over the labor; so the laborers are worn out and consumed as means, and the works, the final goals, remain behind as the yield of history, as Babylon's rubble, as Egypt's pyramids, as memorials of the masses of personal powers that in the course of the ages have been sacrificed to fate.

The spirit of Providence, of the ideal of conscience, of the eternal purpose is personal, and for that very reason just. In this kingdom of spirit each human being [77] receives his gift as personal task. He who received the greatest power received also the greatest burden. Here the gift corresponds exactly to the burden, the work to the responsibility, the reward to the exertion; here the greatest receives no more, and can receive no more, than the least; for the least as well as the greatest receives, each according to his exertion in faith, the whole personal truth.

IV.

The One Thing Needful.

But without faith it is impossible to please God; for he that cometh to God must believe that he is, and that he is a rewarder of them that seek him.

"Nature must help itself": this rule, which surely holds much validity in medicine, seems almost capable of being transferred to ethics, when one sees everything worldly. For is it not strange how the personal natural dispositions can mock upbringing and cultivation; how a good nature can bring itself up in spite of bad examples, and a bad nature harden itself against the best examples; how an independent nature, now [78] pliant, now contentious, can maintain its individuality under strong external pressure,

while the weak, dependent nature cannot by any supporting surroundings whatever be helped over its innate immaturity.

In the worldly sense there is here of course, in this as in every other temporal inequality, an arbitrariness of chance, an injustice of fate; but in the divine sense fate is guilt, and the guilt is man's own.

That this is so can indeed be heard, when those concerned begin to complain of fate.

If the weak man complains that he must stand back for the strong man; he may well be right in the temporal; for in everything temporal the strong nature accomplishes far more than the weak. But before God the weak man accuses himself; for before God faith counts as the one thing needful, and in faith the difference is removed.

In order to believe, the strong man must become weak, like the weakest; for God is strong only in the weak. If there were here any finite difference, then the advantage would surely rather be on the side of the weaker; but here there is no difference: [79] natural weakness and natural strength vanish alike in the weakness that alone counts before God. So equality before God is posited in the inward, and all the inequality that belongs to the outward, the whole outward-going activity, is then to be regarded as the vanishing, which does not concern the personal self.

If it is a restless, passionate mind, tormented in inner distraction, that would compare itself with the deliberate, calm individuality, harmoniously disposed by nature, and complain of its fate: then this complaint too will be heard by God as a self-accusation; for faith is demanded, and in faith the difference is removed.

The naturally calm man must be shaken and disquieted to the utmost, in order to reach faith; and the naturally restless man finds rest and peace when he comes to faith. Faith is not a little rest and a little unrest, or sheer peace in some and sheer unpeace in others; but faith is everywhere and in all the eternal's unrest in all natural rest, the eternal's peace in all natural unpeace. The inequality in the mixture of peace and unpeace, that as a consequence of the individualities' natural diversity [80] remains, belongs to the temporal world, the temporal struggle, and is subordinate to the personal self.

If the gentler, softer nature would complain in comparison with the harder and hardier, that the latter finds it far easier to bear the dispensations of life; then this complainer too is heard by God as one who accuses himself. Existence may be hard and severe; the nature that is hardy has in the temporal the unmistakable advantage that it hardens itself more easily against the blows of fate than the unfortunate man

who received the softer, gentler mind. But in faith the difference is removed. The task of faith is not too severe for anyone, for it is infinitely mild; it is not too mild for anyone, for it is infinitely severe. The heavenly Father is not like an earthly father a little more compliant toward the compliant, a little more hard toward the hard; no, the God of Providence is essentially equally gracious and equally severe toward all natures.

As there can be an obstinacy in hardness, so there can also be an obstinacy in [81] whimpering softness: the holy severity consumes all natural obstinacy; but, when the divine fire has consumed the human obstinate element, it transforms itself into mildness, into infinite mercy. Therefore no human being shall know his faith by this, that he has severity alone, and no one by this, that he has mildness alone; but amid all the differences of individualities everyone can know his faith by this, that it always has severity in mildness and mildness in severity.

At times we human beings complain that faith is too unearthly, too spiritual, too overstrained, so that it does not really permit us to look at the temporal, to rejoice in the purely human and to work in the present. It is natural that this complaint arises in everyone who to any degree exerts himself with the task of faith; let us then complain, the one about this, the other about that, if only we know that before God we accuse ourselves.

One thing is needful; this One is faith, in faith unconditional acknowledgment of the demands of conscience, in faith unconditional humbling under the ideal of person- [82] ality, in faith unconditional obedience to the laws of the ideal, in faith unconditional trust in the promises of the ideal; when a human being in inward earnestness strives to hold fast this One: then let him live in the world as he can and will, solitary or in company, fasting in the desert or enjoying in society: there shall be blessing in it all, and it shall all turn out to his good.

But without faith it is impossible.

The temporal as temporal is not to a certain degree indifferent to God; it is infinitely indifferent. Temporal want, temporal pain, temporal joy, temporal enjoyment, all this is in itself nothing; here no pity of finitude counts, no whimpering and no lamenting, all temporal things go and shall go according to the order of nature: man in flesh and blood is “dust and ashes,” a nothing for God, as the world in all its glory and all its misery is a nothing for God, the Almighty. But, precisely because the temporal in its temporality is infinitely indifferent, it is, as means and condition for man’s personal education, of infinite validity. Providence has not, like Odin, only one eye; Providence

has millions of eyes, an eye with every human being, an eye in every conscience. In the throng of the generations, in the press of events no soul is forgotten, and no [83] accident is accidental.

The powers of the world make a din, the Almighty is silent; the powers of the world arm themselves and defend their right, the Almighty is so still and calm! Let those who can be content with a little right and a little wrong, a little guilt and a little fate, interpret this as they will: every human being who in the name of conscience would be saved from the violence of fate must acknowledge that Providence is revealed, that the knot is untied, that there is help for everyone who will let himself be helped.

But without faith it is impossible; for faith in Providence is the help of Providence.

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